MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 4: Studying Shakespearean Adaptations

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Adaptations reveal new possibilities by changing a familiar story's viewpoint, cultural setting, medium, or political question.

Start with a picture

Tell the same school incident from the teacher's view, then a quiet pupil's, then through a short film without dialogue. The events overlap, but the important questions change. Adaptation works through such choices rather than repetition alone.

1. Beyond the fidelity test

Fidelity asks how closely a new work follows its source. That can be useful for describing changes, but "different" is not automatically "wrong." Ask what the alteration achieves and why it matters to a new audience.

An adaptation can criticise its source, amplify a marginal voice, or test whether an old structure works under different conditions.

2. Stoppard: change the centre

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead moves Hamlet's peripheral courtiers into the foreground. Repeated coin tosses, uncertainty about roles, and the Players connect adaptation with absurdist theatre and metatheatre.

The encounter with an already familiar plot makes fate tangible: the characters appear trapped within a narrative spectators may already know. Yet the letter and their service to Claudius keep responsibility in view.

3. Jacobson: change the conversation

Shylock Is My Name shifts The Merchant of Venice into contemporary Cheshire and brings Shylock into dialogue with Simon Strulovitch. Jewish identity, antisemitism, daughters' independence, paternal control, and the conditions of mercy become central.

The new bond revisits the power to make another body vulnerable. Self-aware dialogue between present concerns and a Shakespearean character gives the novel postmodern and

intertextual features. The novel’s title is sometimes reversed in the textbook; keep the published form.

4. Kurosawa: change medium and history

Ran draws on King Lear but alters gender relationships, political history, and motivation. Three sons replace Lear’s daughters. Hidetora’s previous violence receives particular emphasis, while Kaede’s revenge reworks the moral history of the conflict.

A camera and soundtrack produce meanings unavailable through plot comparison alone. Colour, scale, framing, stylised performance, and sound can place individual ambition against a devastating historical world.

5. Foreshadowing in Ran

Foreshadowing prepares an audience for later developments. The course reads early divisions among the mounted figures and the old boar episode as visual suggestions of conflict and the ageing ruler’s vulnerability. Explain these as interpretations of cinematic details, not universal meanings every image must carry.

6. A five-part comparison method

1. **Viewpoint:** whose experience organises the new work?
2. **Setting:** which social and historical relationships change?
3. **Medium:** what can stage, prose, or cinema express differently?
4. **Conflict:** what new ethical or political pressure becomes central?
5. **Effect:** how does the change alter the audience’s judgement of the source?

A good comparison uses a paired example. Do not summarise the original, summarise the adaptation, and leave the relationship unexplained.

Quick check

1. Is a new viewpoint a meaningful adaptation change? **Yes.**
2. Does a cinematic essay need more than character matching? **Yes; framing, editing, performance, and sound matter.**
3. Is fidelity the only basis for judgement? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define transformation beyond simple fidelity.
2. Analyse Stoppard’s viewpoint and theatrical form.
3. Analyse Jacobson’s modern dialogue and identity questions.
4. Analyse Kurosawa’s history and cinematic methods.
5. Compare what each makes newly visible in Shakespeare.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not insist that every new character has exactly one original equivalent. Correct the Jacobson title and avoid confusing a film’s symbolism with a literal historical record.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare how the three adaptations transform Shakespeare rather than merely reproduce him.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The prescribed adaptations share an engagement with Shakespeare but alter different dimensions of the source. Stoppard changes the distribution of attention, Jacobson changes the cultural conversation, and Kurosawa transforms the historical world and medium. The value of comparing them lies in identifying how each change produces a new problem for its audience.

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead makes the experience of peripheral characters central. Their lack of understanding and their dependence on fragments of Hamlet turn a familiar plot into a structure of uncertainty. The metatheatrical Players further question whether knowing the conventions of a story grants control over one’s place within it. Adaptation becomes a method of examining fate and responsibility.

Shylock Is My Name brings a historically burdened representation into modern dialogue. The encounter with Strulovitch keeps the earlier character present while reopening questions of prejudice, family authority, and mercy. Its intertextual method prevents a clean separation between the source’s past and the present audience’s assumptions. The new work asks not only how Shylock has changed, but how the judgement of him has been inherited.

Ran makes transformation visible through cinematic choices and an altered political history. Its landscapes, colour patterns, stylised movement, and controlled soundtrack develop an ethical emphasis on the return of violence. A fidelity score could note differences but would not explain those effects. The stronger question is how a recognisable tragic structure becomes a distinct artistic argument. Across all three works, adaptation demonstrates that a classic remains active through revision, contest, and new forms of attention.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. How does Stoppard’s play change the focus of its source material?

2. Examine the actions of Rosencrantz and Guildenstern in Stoppard’s play.
3. In what ways are the plot of Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead absurdist?
4. How does My Name is Shylock revisit Shakespeare.
5. Detail My Name is Shylock as a work of postmodernist fiction.
6. Explore the changes Kurosawa made to the plot of King Lear.
7. What are the different techniques used to foreshadow plot developments in Ran?